

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 265

Culture (OWC): [Tsonga \(FT06\)](#)

Region: Africa

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Section Title(S)

SOCIAL INTERACTION: THE CONTEXT FOR THE CLASH OF SUBCULTURES

An event unique to those who live near the coast is the all-women activity of gathering shellfish. This occurs at spring tides (at the new moon) when whole communities of women may descend on the rocks at low tide, in seminaked strip, armed with a variety of weapons from bush knives to sharpened vehicle leaf-springs. To the accompaniment of riotous laughter and lewd jokes, the women proceed to hack a harvest of mussels and redbait from the rocks. It is hazardous and hard work, but the communality of the labour, like the work party, creates a strong sense of common commitment, which is usually expressed in the Tsonga language.

222

Collecting

462

Division Of Labor By Gender

562

Gender Status

Rock stripping is strictly a female preserve. Any man happening by is subjected to the most humiliating insults, invariably of a sexual nature. Any indiscretions of his past (or present) are ruthlessly exposed or, if he has none, he is scorned for incompetence, impotence, or worse. Legend has it that some fifteen years ago, a white (male) official of a conservation body tried to enforce a ban on shellfish harvesting. When he came to enforce the ban, he was surrounded by a group of about twenty women, who simultaneously lifted their aprons to him, exposing themselves. There is no greater insult. Today, amid ribald laughter, participants in the event still remind each other of the event, which ended in a victory for them.

222

Collecting

462

Division Of Labor By Gender

576

Etiquette

Funerals, weddings and pension pay-outs are the other occasions when large numbers of people gather. At weddings and funerals, men and women usually sit separately and women rehearse their Tsonga with each other. Such occasions draw together people not just from the locality, but from far-flung areas, so a broader cross-fertilisation takes place, as women exchange

464

Labor Supply And Employment

562

anecdotes, gossip and news. In the course of the feast that follows, the status of the senior women is given symbolic expression when they share the eating of the head of the sacrificed beast with the senior men.

Gender Status

Women have developed the technique of humiliation to a fine art. It is the most frequently used weapon in the gender context and is played out in public, whenever there is a suitable audience. There is a marked edge of competition in the humour, which takes the form of banter, couched in the idiom of a joking relationship so that no offence may be taken if the barbs are too pointed. Frequently in a shebeen or some other gathering point women will gather in cliques, making jokes in Tsonga and casting meaningful glances at the butt of their humour, who comprehends little, save that he is being pilloried.

522
Humor

562
Gender Status

576
Etiquette

Particularly abrasive and hostile humour is reserved for returning migrants, especially if they are prone to parading around the community in new clothes, fancy shoes and mirrored sunglasses. Drink parties, or the communal waterhole, serve as the stage where women of all ages act out elaborate charades ■266 parodying such dandies, playing with particular relish if one such unfortunate is present. The main form of humiliation takes the form of shouting, in Tsonga, a stream of invective and/or jokes in poor taste, into the face of the victim. He may not understand the words, but there is no mistaking the message.

156
Social Personality

522
Humor

576
Etiquette

626
Social Control

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